Once upon a time, treatments for heart or brain disease in dogs were palliative in nature—you gave painkillers to ensure a dignified end of life. Today, there is a whole range of intervention procedures—even something like an erratic heartbeat can be fixed. Pacemakers—that generate impulses which allow regular heart beats—on dogs are implanted at several Indian hospitals.

Seventy to 80 per cent of dogs over the age of eight also have mitral valve disease, in which the leaflets (or flaps) of heart valves become thick, resulting in the backflow of blood, which can be remedied with hybrid surgery. "I do it within one-two hours," says Dr Bhanu. "We clamp down the leaflets laproscopically and the backflow reduces."

Dogs suffering from hydrocephalus, where there is a build-up of fluid in the brain, are now being treated with an advanced surgery called VP shunting, where a tube is inserted into the brain to drain out the fluid. "We did the first procedure of this kind in 2019," says Dr Kunal. "Since then, we have been doing more neurological surgeries. Today, we operate on brain and spinal tumours around 7-8 times a week."

JOINT INTERVENTION

Arthritis is another ailment that besets overweight dogs. "Eight out of 10 dogs have a weight issue today and, correspondingly, joint issues," says Dr Kunal. To help them, hospitals have 3D printing of joints. "These are custom-made for knee replacement, hip replacement or leg alignment surgeries. We can even print out bones to perform a mock surgery, which can reduce time and improve outcomes in real surgery," says Dr Kunal. Other treatments include hydrotherapy, laser therapy, therapeutic ultrasound and anti-inflammatory injectables. "We can do total joint replacements if needed," he adds. A far cry from the time, in 2008, when 51-year-old Akshay Batra, a marketing manager from Pune, flew to the US to get joint implants for his Labrador. "Those days, importing implants took long, so I carried a vet's prescription and got them and he did the surgery here," he says.

CANINE LIFE SAVERS

The new procedures for dogs being offered in India, the cost of treatment and availability

↘ BALLOON VALVULOPLASTY

A procedure that opens up narrowing heart valves using a catheter with a balloon at its tip **Cost:** Rs 2-4 lakh; **Available at:** Max Petz; Devashrya Animal Hospital, Faridabad

↘ CARDIOVASCULAR STENTS

Keep narrowing arteries wide for passage of blood
Cost: Rs 50,000-1.5 lakh
Available at: DCC Animal Hospital, Delhi; Devashrya

↘ HYBRID SURGERY FOR MITRAL VALVE DISEASE

In older dogs, flaps of heart valves become thick, with backflow of blood, Can be treated in one-two hours
Cost: Rs 2-4 lakh
Available at: Tata Trust Hospital, Blue 7 Vets

↘ PACEMAKERS

Implanted laproscopically, they generate impulses for regular heart beats
Cost: Rs 1.5-3 lakh
Available at: Cessna Lifeline, CGS Hospital

↘ VP SHUNTING

A tube inserted in the brain to drain out fluid build-up, a condition called hydrocephalus
Cost: Rs 50,000-2.5 lakh
Available at: Max Petz

↘ PERINEAL URETHROSTOMY

Enlargement of the urethral opening if a dog has trouble urinating
Cost: Rs 10,000-20,000
Available at: CGS Hospital, Bangalore Pet Hospital

↘ GENETIC BIOMARKERS

Kits that check if dogs are predisposed to a disease
Cost: Rs 3,000-25,000
Available at: EasyDna India, Urban Animal

↘ HYDROTHERAPY/ LASER THERAPY/ ANTI-INFLAMMATORY INJECTABLES

Helps reduce arthritic pain
Cost: Rs 500-Rs 2,500; Rs 4,000-Rs 8 lakh; Rs 100-Rs 1,000
Available at: DCC Animal Hospital, CGS Animal Hospital

A LIMITED FACILITY

If there is a problem, it is that many of the new advanced procedures are available only in select hospitals. The reasons for this are multifold. Firstly, such surgeries require training abroad. "We need an expert anaesthesiologist, vascular surgeons, someone to manage imaging in the OT. You need 5-6 specialised vets for each procedure. Finding specialised vets is not easy," says Dr Bhanu. The high cost of new equipment is another big reason since small clinics cannot afford them.

Holding out hope is the 'one earth, one health' approach, which believes in holistic healthcare for all living beings. "Since canines require almost the same equipment as humans, many countries are exploring the possibility of having the same healthcare facility for humans and dogs," says Dr Kunal.

Companion dogs' lives have changed forever. Gone are the days when they were left to roam in the garden or fed bread and milk. They now lie about in air-conditioned rooms and share potato chips with us on the couch. The impact on their health—and the need to set it right using cutting-edge modern medicine—is part of the new reality. ■